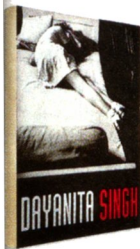


Testaments in SHADES

Dayanita Singh's uniquely personal photographs explore the mystery of ordinary spaces and defy immediate identification. No pretty pictures for this artist of shadowlands.



DAYANITA SINGH
Penguin Studio
Price: Rs 5,999
Pages: 231

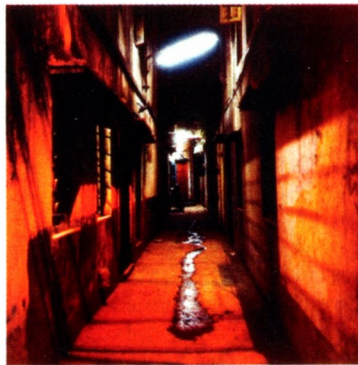
By Dilip Bobb

If photography is considered a creative avenue of self-expression, Dayanita Singh's work is an urgent exclamation of angst. She does not believe in pretty pictures. Her world is stark and real, sometimes disturbingly so, focused on contemporary middle class urban life. It's her view of the world with all its imperfections, darkness rather than light, shadows rather than the substance, obscurities as opposed to the obvious. What accentuates this even more is that a majority of her work has been in black and white and the photographs in all her books so far come without caption or explanation. This book combines all her pub-

lished work in one volume and allows us to evaluate her transition from black and white photography to colour, as in her last two books, which includes *Dream Villa*, the largest single body of her colour work in which she explores the mysteriousness of ordinary spaces obscured in darkness. Singh's photographs are uniquely personal, giving little away in terms of explanation, context, place or time. The photographer prefers to let the work speak for itself and her subjects tend to defy immediate identification.

She has largely chosen to document a slice of India that exists in the narrow space between ambition and achievement and, occasionally, the space occupied by the marginalised. Her most ambitious work to date has been the 13 years

she spent on a black and white series on a eunuch which resulted in a book, *Myself Mona Ahmed*, but the bulk of her creative output has focused on the urban middle class (*Ladies of Calcutta*), working, partying, marrying and even sleeping. More recently, she has turned to another kind of portraiture, but of places rather than people: empty chairs in an elongated room, private homes, libraries, ballrooms, museums, wedding venues and, in a tribute to her childhood, an ashram in Varanasi (*I am As I am*). Her recent work in colour also explores places, but industrial ones, stark, even surreal shots of ordinary rusting boilers and pipes. Whether in colour or black and white, Singh's photos are so personal to her that it lies in the individual eyes of the beholder to interpret them in whichever way they want. The reality of her work is that what some find distorted and disturbing, others will discover beauty, even brilliance. ■



(CLOCKWISE FROM TOP) PICTURES FROM SINGH'S MYSELF MONA AHMED; DREAM VILLA; AND I AM AS I AM